Sourav Selvaraj

Research interests: contact-rich control and learning for legged systems.

souravselvaraj.github.io
github.com/souravselvaraj
sselvaraj@wpi.edu

Education

- **Worcester Polytechnic Institute** — Worcester, MA
  Master of Science in Robotics Engineering — *Aug 2025 – May 2027 (expected)*
  - **GPA:** 4.0/4.0
  - **Coursework:** Robot Control, Motion Planning, Legged Robotics, Machine Learning for Robotics
- **National Institute of Technology, Tiruchirappalli** — Tiruchirappalli, India
  B.Tech in Instrumentation and Control Engineering — *Dec 2021 – May 2025*
  - **CGPA:** 8.2/10.0
  - **Coursework:** Control Systems, Robotics, Signal Processing, Machine Learning, Embedded Systems

Manuscripts

[1] **S. Selvaraj**, J. P. Espinosa Chessal, and M. Agheli, "SCRUB: Contact-Based Surface-Frame Estimation for Force–Motion Control with an Armless Quadruped." Submitted to IEEE RA-L, 2026. `arXiv:2611.06649`.

[2] O. Sullivan*, **S. Selvaraj***, and M. Agheli, "GaitNet: Learning to Choose the Gait for a Model-Based Locomotion Controller." To be submitted to L4DC 2027. *Equal contribution.

Research Experience

- **SCRUB: Armless Quadruped Body-Tool Sliding** [`video`] — ALMaS Research Group, WPI
  Graduate Researcher; Advisor: Dr. Mahdi Agheli — *Aug 2025 – Present*
  - Developed **SCRUB** for force-controlled tool sliding on a Unitree Go1 without a surface model.
  - Derived a friction-independent surface-normal cue from tool forces.
  - Extended a **100 Hz** OCS2 centroidal MPC to plan the tool's contact, over a **1 kHz** whole-body controller.
  - Completed **5/5** wall and **5/5** column trials at 10 N, with **2.29°/2.48°** normal error and **2.97/2.06 N** force RMSE; fixed-normal and friction-compensated baselines completed **0/5** column trials.
- **GaitNet: Attention-Based RL Footstep Planning** — ALMaS Research Group, WPI
  Graduate Researcher; Advisor: Dr. Mahdi Agheli — *Nov 2025 – Present*
  - Implemented **GaitNet-T** with 4-head attention over candidate footholds and a motion-history encoder.
  - Built controller-specific **IDMs**: OCS2 landing error **6→2 cm** RMS, success **55→83%**.
  - In simulation with camera terrain, GaitNet reached **70%** at 40–70% voids vs **38%** for OCS2 trot.
- **TOTO: Autonomous Mobile Robot** — NIT Trichy, India
  Undergraduate Researcher; Advisor: Dr. D. Ezhilarasi — *Sep 2024 – May 2025*
  - Built an **ICP-SLAM** stack with an Iterated Kalman Filter fusing encoders and RPLiDAR.
  - Achieved ±2% velocity-tracking error; observability-aware point selection cut ICP processing by **10%**.
- **Biomimetic Autonomous Underwater Vehicle** — IIT Madras, India
  Research Intern; Advisor: Dr. Asokan Thondiyath — *Mar 2023 – Sep 2023*
  - Designed a Jetson Orin interface PCB and CAN motor control for Maxon BLDC propulsion drives.

Honors & Awards

- **Dr. Glenn Yee Graduate Student Tuition Award** — WPI, Worcester
  Awarded to graduate students for academic excellence — *Fall 2026*
- **Winner, Smart India Hackathon** — Ministry of Education, India
  Awarded in a nationwide student innovation competition — *2023*

Selected Projects

Code and demonstration videos: `github.com/souravselvaraj`

- **Humanoid Ice Skating with RL** [video] *Jul 2026 – Present*
  - Trained a simulated Unitree G1 to skate with PPO on passive two-edge blades without motion capture.
  - One policy tracked 0.9 m/s with **0.09 m/s** error, **94%** single support, and **2–4 cm/s** lateral slip.
- **Humanoid Bimanual Lifting with Residual AMP–PPO** [code] *May 2026 – Jul 2026*
  - Collaborated on training a G1 to lift objects via residual AMP–PPO over a fixed locomotion policy.
  - Held objects within **3 cm** of the target in simulation.
  - Ran a lifting policy from the project on the real G1 with a box.
- **Crazyflie SE(3) Control with L1 Adaptation** [code] *Oct 2025 – Dec 2025*
  - Implemented an SE(3) controller with L1 adaptation for a simulated Crazyflie 2.1 in ROS 2 and Gazebo.
  - Achieved **2.2 cm** x/y position RMSE and cancelled **94/86/71%** of a roll/pitch/yaw step torque.

Additional: Flow matching (`code`); ORB-SLAM; visuomotor imitation (`code`); PDDL/OMPL.

Teaching Experience

- **RBE 521: Legged Robotics** Worcester Polytechnic Institute
  Teaching Assistant & Laboratory Curriculum Developer *May 2026 – Aug 2026*
  - Served as RBE 521 TA with Dr. Mahdi Agheli and developed Unitree Go1/G1 lab modules.

Academic Service & Leadership

- **Reviewer:** *IEEE Transactions on Automation Science and Engineering (T-ASE)*, Jan–Feb 2026.
- **Team Lead, ISRO Robotics Challenge:** Led a 10-person autonomous-rover team, Dec 2022–Aug 2024.

Skills

Software: ROS 2, Isaac Lab, MuJoCo, Gazebo, OCS2, Pinocchio, PyTorch, Docker
Programming: C/C++, Python, MATLAB/Simulink
Robotics: MPC, Whole-Body Control, Trajectory Optimization, Reinforcement Learning, Imitation Learning
Hardware: Unitree Go1/G1, Franka Panda, Crazyflie 2.1, Jetson Orin, RealSense, F/T Sensors